

Cover Brief

Fill-in template — write it before you look at a single image

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Companion to Writing with Claude, Chapter 11, Build 2. Write this before you look at a single image, whether the designer is a person or an AI. Give it to Claude with your Canon and thesis and say: "Draft my cover brief from these." Then rewrite "What the book actually is" and "Tone" yourself — if those two sections sound like anyone else's book, the cover will look like anyone else's cover. The avoid list is the disqualifier: a concept that uses anything on it ends the conversation.

Project at a glance

Field	Your book
Title	(locked text for layout)
Subtitle	(locked text for layout)
Author	
Format	e.g. paperback + Kindle via KDP; hardcover via IngramSpark
Genre / category	Store category, in the store's words
Length	~ __, __ words / ~ __ pages, __ x __ trim
Target ship date	

Audience

Who picks this up, and what else is on their nightstand. Name three books they already own. What makes them put a book down.

What the book actually is

One paragraph, in your words. The promise, the voice, the reason it exists. Then the two or three signature ideas a concept can anchor on — a metaphor, a question, a phrase from the book — and how literally each one may be shown.

Tone

Three or four adjectives and a comparison a designer can picture ("editorial book section, not vendor booth"). What the cover should make the reader feel before they read a word.

The two jobs

Every cover has to do two things that pull against each other. Say how you want them balanced:

- 1 **Credibility at print scale** — what it must feel like in the hand.
- 2 **Presence at thumbnail scale** — most discovery happens at about 200 pixels tall. Bold color, dominant title typography, one conceptual element.

Reference covers

Four to eight real covers, split into what to learn from each: typography discipline, thumbnail presence, conceptual confidence. Say what ties them together.

Avoid list — the disqualifier

The cliches of your shelf. Be specific (for a cybersecurity book: glowing padlocks, hooded hackers, falling green code, world maps with red dots). Any concept that uses one is a no, and you say so up front.

The authenticity rule

If anything on the cover depicts something real — an object, a place, a person — it is verified real or it is not on the cover. (The Treasure Hunter's Legacy shipped with photographs of an actual eight-reale coin, not AI-generated pirate silver.)

Deliverables

- 1 Ebook front cover — e.g. 1600 x 2560 px, sRGB, JPG
- 2 Paperback full wrap — back + spine + front as one print-ready PDF to platform spec
- 3 Source files — layered working file, fonts packaged or outlined, so revisions are possible

Technical specifications

Trim size. Interior paper and page count (provisional until frozen). Spine width from the platform's cover calculator. Full-wrap dimensions including bleed. Resolution (300 DPI). Color space (CMYK wrap, sRGB ebook). Safety zones. File formats. What the author supplies for the back cover: blurb (~150 words), bio (~50 words), headshot, barcode box.

Fill this section from 05_Cover_wrap_Spec.md once the page count is frozen. Until then, mark every number provisional.

Timeline and rounds

Concept round, revision rounds, final files. How many rounds are included. Your exit criteria for any "modify the existing cover" request — set the time limit before it starts.

How to respond

Portfolio links in this genre, a quote, and one paragraph on how they would approach the brief. Instincts, not a free concept.